



DONNIE BATS

ACTIVITY PACK

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DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

The Legend of Donnie Bats by Jeff Kurrus

After reading the book, talk about these questions with a friend, a teacher, or your family.

1. In the beginning of the book, Donnie can't hit, throw, or catch well, but he still loves baseball. Name something you're not good at yet but still love to do. Why?

2. Think about the moment in the story when Donnie first realizes he might have a talent. Draw or describe what that moment looked like. What was Donnie's face doing?

3. Donnie is alone when he discovers his talent. Why do you think it happened that way? What do you think he was feeling in that moment?

4. Donnie keeps playing baseball even when things go wrong. Do you think that makes him brave, stubborn, determined, or something else? Pick one word and explain why.

5. If you woke up tomorrow with a hidden talent nobody knew about, what might it be? How would your friends find out?

BASEBALL WORD SEARCH

Find all 12 words from the book hidden in the grid

S	Y	J	B	W	D	W	A	U	Y	U	A	I
Z	Q	K	F	D	V	S	M	A	J	D	A	S
J	H	Y	H	A	K	S	S	I	L	Q	Q	P
A	O	F	P	W	V	D	V	E	C	K	A	I
Z	M	B	N	O	U	I	I	R	A	K	E	T
Z	E	O	Z	E	W	F	P	E	B	L	O	C
N	R	M	I	K	R	E	L	E	M	Q	Z	H
P	U	B	S	E	U	B	R	U	R	Y	K	X
R	N	F	T	C	U	J	E	M	P	S	R	Q
S	V	T	N	O	C	G	M	G	I	P	C	H
E	A	O	D	T	A	X	R	S	X	T	Y	B
S	W	S	K	C	U	T	R	I	P	L	E	Q
S	I	N	G	L	E	B	S	T	B	Q	E	S

WORDS TO FIND

RAKE
PITCH
TRIPLE

BOMB
HOMERUN
VIPERS

JAZZ
DOUBLE
SATTERFIELD

CAGE
SINGLE
POWERMITES

BASEBALL VOCABULARY MATCH

Write the letter of the matching meaning on the line next to each word.

- | | | | |
|----------|--------|----|---|
| 1. _____ | RAKE | A. | A hit that lets the batter run to second base |
| 2. _____ | BOMB | B. | To hit the ball really well (slang) |
| 3. _____ | CAGE | C. | The fenced-in area where players practice |
| 4. _____ | SINGLE | D. | A hit that lets the batter run to third base |
| 5. _____ | DOUBLE | E. | A really long home run (slang) |
| 6. _____ | TRIPLE | F. | A hit that lets the batter reach first base |

BE LIKE DONNIE CHALLENGE

Every kid has a special talent. Time to find yours.

Donnie didn't know his talent until he tried. This week, try something hard.
It doesn't have to be baseball. It just has to be something you haven't done before.

MY CHALLENGE THIS WEEK

Write down one hard thing you're going to try.

WHAT HAPPENED

After you tried it, write what happened. Good or bad.

WHAT I LEARNED

What did you learn about yourself?

MY HIDDEN TALENT MIGHT BE

Based on what you tried, what could your talent be?

“Greatness Lives in Every Kid”

Share your challenge with a friend, a teacher, or your family.

A NOTE FROM JEFF

I have always wanted to tell a baseball story. As a former player, coach, and lifelong lover of this game, I wanted to share all the silly things that make this game so much fun.

Donnie was also, at first, based off my son, Eli, until the fictional Donnie took over the story and led me in the direction he wanted to go.

This has been the most enjoyable book I have ever written, for there are many parts based on situations I have seen with my own eyes.

I hope it is the most enjoyable book you've read, of course, but I also hope it reminds you of the hidden talents that you have and why they are so important to keep searching for.

I live in Gretna, Nebraska, with my wife and three kids. I edit Nebraskaland Magazine. I take pictures of wildlife and write about the outdoors. I visit schools and talk to students about writing.

If your kid read this book and has something to say about it, I'd like to hear it. Write me at jeffreyekurrus@gmail.com.

Thanks for reading.

Jeff Kurrus

Author and photographer, Gretna, Nebraska



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For teachers and librarians

Turn the page for how this pack supports your classroom standards.

FOR TEACHERS AND LIBRARIANS

EDUCATOR HANDOUT

How this pack supports your classroom standards

The Legend of Donnie Bats is a chapter book written for reluctant readers in grades 3 to 5 (ages 7 to 12). The activities in this pack are designed to build comprehension, vocabulary, written response, and discussion skills around a single accessible text. The mapping below shows how each activity supports the standards your school already uses.

Core ELA alignment (Common Core / Nebraska 2021 ELA, grades 3 to 5)

Discussion Questions 2 and 3 ask students to refer explicitly to a moment in the text and describe a character's traits and feelings (**RL.3.1, RL.3.3, RL.4.1, RL.4.3, RL.5.3**). **Question 4** asks students to choose between related words that describe states of mind (*brave, stubborn, determined*) and defend the choice, supporting **L.3.5.C** shades of meaning and **W.3.1 / W.4.1 / W.5.1** opinion writing with reasons. **Questions 1 and 5** ask for short opinion or narrative responses connecting the book to the student's own life (**L.3.5.B** real-life connections; **W.3.3 / W.4.3 / W.5.3** narrative writing). The **Be Like Donnie Challenge** produces a structured narrative recount of a real experience with reflection and a conclusion (**W.3.3.A, W.3.3.B, W.3.3.D**). The **matching activity** on the word search page builds vocabulary acquisition through definition pairing (**L.3.4, L.3.6**). All discussion questions are designed for pair, group, or family conversation, supporting **SL.3.1 / SL.4.1 / SL.5.1**.

English language learner support (WIDA ELD Standards Framework, 2020 Edition)

The pack engages all four **WIDA Key Language Uses**. **Narrate** (Questions 2 and 5; the Challenge), **Inform** (Question 1, stating reasons), **Explain** (Question 3, explaining a character's feelings), and **Argue** (Question 4, defending a word choice). Every prompt offers both an interpretive and an expressive entry point. Students may draw, describe, or write, which aligns with the **ELD-LA.3-5** Language Expectations and supports the Proficiency Level Descriptors for the expressive mode. The matching activity gives newcomer and developing learners a scaffolded entry point to domain-specific baseball vocabulary drawn directly from the book (*rake, bomb, cage, single, double, triple*).

Why this book reaches readers schools often struggle to engage

The Legend of Donnie Bats is built for the readers most schools report the hardest to reach: boys ages 7 to 12 who prefer sports, the outdoors, or hands-on activities over fiction. The book's themes carry a clear social and emotional learning thread alongside its ELA work. Effort without natural talent. The courage to keep trying. The value of a hidden gift. **Jeff Kurrus** is an award-winning photographer and the author of four children's books, including *Have You Seen Mary?*, a Nebraska Golden Sower Award nominee. While this book and pack are best suited for grades 3 to 5, Jeff's in-person school programs span K-8, including Writer's Workshops, Author Q&A sessions, and a Photography Workshop for grades 6 to 8. As Jeff puts it, *"I wrote this book for the kids who tell me they don't like to read. Most of them like baseball, or being outside, or anything that isn't sitting still with a book."*

This pack pairs with Jeff's in-person school programs, including Writer's Workshops that scaffold all four WIDA Key Language Uses (Narrate, Inform, Explain, Argue). Explore the full Author Visit Packet at jeffkurrus.com/school-visits.

To inquire about a school visit or classroom program

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